

Week 6 Enabling Activities

Synthesis & Judgment

This set covers the full six-activity family for Synthesis & Judgment, organized as two tracks: 1a–1c build the Tensions → Priorities → Judgment move in stages; 4a–4c test whether it has proceduralized. Because W6 is the spiral week, every activity also requires integrating at least one prior frame (W1–W5) — that requirement is folded into each activity's content. These supplement — they do not replace — this week's folder and the ESO/Frames Daily Protocol.

This Week's Frame — Synthesis & Judgment (W6)

Tensions	Priorities	Judgment
What competing claims must be addressed?	Which consideration carries more weight, and why?	What is the most defensible conclusion?

Key requirement: every response this week integrates at least one prior frame (W1–W5) as part of naming the tensions or defending the priority. A response that names a tension but never commits to a priority is operating at ILR 2+, not ILR 3 — describing disagreement is not the same as resolving it. The judgment must name which priority wins and why.

Activity Index

1a. Single-Scenario Depth Ladder · 1b. Sentence-Frame Progression · 1c. 3-Interval Comparison & Paraphrase · 4a. 2-Box Induction · 4b. Silent Protocol & Brief-Back · 4c. Strategic Competence & Fallback

Single-Scenario Depth Ladder — "Scaffold the Scaffold"

Holds one low-stakes scenario constant while building the Tensions → Priorities → Judgment move in four steps. Item 2 adds priority-setting alone; Item 3 adds the spiral defense — a prior frame's move used to justify that priority — together with the judgment. Item 4 removes all support and doesn't name which prior frame to use.

ANCHOR SCENARIO (HELD CONSTANT ACROSS ITEMS 1–3)

A country is deciding whether to adopt a universal basic income (UBI).

1

Surface

"What are the two competing claims in the UBI debate?"

Name one tension only — one value pulling each way (for example, security for low-income families versus cost to taxpayers)

2

Surface → Deep

"Which consideration should carry more weight here?"

Add the Priorities box. State which one wins — the defense comes next, not yet.

3

Deep

"If reducing poverty is weighted more heavily than short-term cost, the most defensible conclusion is that a country _____. Defend that weighting using a trade-off: what's given up either way, and why is one loss more tolerable than the other?"

Complete the Judgment and defend it with a prior-frame move in the same response.

4

Transfer

"Should countries replace their current retirement age with a flexible retirement window based on job type?"

Full response: tensions + priorities + judgment, integrating at least one prior frame of your choosing, no connector given.

Instructor note: this is the hardest week's ladder — expect it to take longer than 5–10 minutes. If a student stalls at Item 3, they likely need more practice with a specific prior frame (probably W2 Trade-offs) before the spiral defense comes easily.

Causal Subordination → Concessive Subordination → Appositive

Builds subordinate-clause complexity in three tiers using connectors that read as ILR 2+/3, not just connectors that are technically subordinating. Coordinating conjunctions (FANBOYS) are excluded — and so are 'because' and 'so': both are grammatically fine, but they're exactly the safe, overused connectors that inflate a proficiency ceiling. T1 uses higher-register causal subordinators with more precision. Unlike every other week, T2 and T3 must name the tension and resolve it toward one side using a prior frame's reasoning, in the same sentence.

SCENARIO

A country is deciding whether to adopt a universal basic income (UBI).

T1

Causal subordination — given that / on the grounds that / considering that

Complete each sentence, naming one priority — no resolution required yet.

- "UBI advocates prioritize poverty reduction given that ____."
- "Skeptics remain cautious about the cost on the grounds that ____."
- "Some economists support a pilot program considering that ____."

T2

Concessive subordination — although / while / even though

Name the tension and resolve it in the same sentence.

- "While critics worry about UBI's cost to taxpayers, that cost is more tolerable than continued poverty because ____."
- "Although a universal payment reaches people who don't strictly need it, the simplicity is worth that inefficiency given that ____."
- "Even though the program requires new taxes, the burden is justified rather than the alternative because ____."

T3

Appositives — "Fact, ____, Fact"

Embed a prior-frame-grounded justification as a defining phrase inside the sentence.

MODEL

"The cost to taxpayers, a burden that critics call disproportionate at the organizational level, is outweighed by the security it provides to individual families living paycheck to paycheck — the same scale-based trade-off that makes redistribution defensible in most safety-net debates."

Instructor note: move to T2 only once T1 is fluent. Unlike other weeks, T3 here is not optional stretch — it's the clearest single-sentence test of whether resolution-plus-integration has landed.

Comparison & Paraphrase Prompts

Connects synthesis vocabulary to comparative sentence structures, moving from a simple one-line comparison to a claim that resolves the comparison and names the prior frame doing the work.

COMPARISON PAIR

How the security UBI provides to individuals compares with its cost to the broader tax base — and which consideration should win.

Target Lexicon — must appear at least once

outweighs

defensible

resolves

in light
of

on
balance

1

Surface

"In one sentence, compare the security UBI provides to individuals with its cost to the broader tax base."

2

Deep

"Using defensible, explain which side of that comparison is stronger and why."

3

Transfer

"Write one complex sentence that resolves the comparison — using outweighs or on balance — and explicitly names which prior frame (W1–W5) justifies your resolution."

Instructor note: score for lexicon use and whether the student explicitly names which prior frame justifies the resolution — not for which side they land

Visual Synthesis

Forces students to distinguish a resolved judgment from a restated tension — and to see the spiral requirement modeled in context — from grouped, unlabeled examples.

SHARED FACTS (BOTH BOXES WORK FROM THIS)

A city is debating whether to close a beloved but financially struggling public swimming pool to save money, or keep it open by raising local taxes.

Box A

- There are good reasons to keep the pool open and good reasons to close it. Both sides have valid points, and the city needs to weigh cost against community value.
- Ultimately, this is a difficult decision that depends on what the city values most.

Box B

- The pool should stay open. At the individual and family level, it's one of the only affordable recreational spaces for lower-income residents — losing it would fall hardest on exactly the households least able to absorb the loss.
- At the organizational level, the tax increase needed is small relative to the whole city budget. Because the burden of closing falls disproportionately on one group while the burden of the tax is spread broadly, keeping the pool open is the more defensible choice.

TASK

What does Box B do that Box A never does? Why isn't "both sides have good points" a judgment, even though it sounds balanced and reasonable? Which prior frame is Box B drawing on to defend its priority?

Instructor note: Box A sounds thoughtful but never commits to a priority or conclusion — it's a restated tension wearing the shape of a judgment. Box commits, and defends the priority using a W1-style scale/stakeholder move. Let the student name both things before you confirm them.

Silent Modeling & Pre-Attempt Brief-Back

Separates rule comprehension from production. Students extract the frame's structure from a marked-but-unexplained model, then must plan out loud before they're allowed to attempt their own response. For W6, the model marks four moves, not three — the fourth being which prior frame is doing the work, since that's the spiral requirement being tested.

PHASE 1 — SILENT MODELING

Read the response below. Four elements are marked [A], [B], [C], [D]. No explanation is given — identify what each represents before moving to Phase 2.

[A] Critics argue UBI is too costly, while advocates insist the security it provides justifies the expense. **[B]** Between those two claims, the security argument carries more weight, because the cost of doing nothing — persistent poverty and its downstream strain on emergency services, healthcare, and lost productivity — is higher than the cost of the program itself. **[C]** Weighing the individual-level benefit of guaranteed income against the organizational-level tax burden — a W1 scale analysis — **[D]** the individual security outweighs the aggregate cost, since the burden is spread thinly across many taxpayers while the benefit is concentrated where it's needed most.

Key (reveal only after Phase 2). In the digital version, each move is color-highlighted. In print, use letter markers above.

	[A] = Tension		[B] = Priority		[C] = Prior Frame Used (W1)		[D] = Judgment
---	-------------------------	---	--------------------------	---	--	---	--------------------------

PHASE 2 — VERBAL BRIEF-BACK ("PLAN BEFORE YOU PRODUCE")

Before attempting your own response to the prompt below, say out loud — or write in one sentence — your plan for each of the frame's three moves. Do not begin your full response until you've stated your plan. For W6: also state which prior frame you will use to defend your priority.

PROMPT FOR PHASE 2 ATTEMPT

"Should a universal basic income replace unemployment benefits entirely, or supplement them?"

Instructor note: the brief-back is a planning checkpoint, not a rehearsal — keep it to one sentence. This models a legitimate strategy: a brief pause to organize before speaking.

Fallback Scaffolding

Tests whether the frame's core move survives without its own vocabulary — the ILR 3 skill of knowing what to do when the exact word isn't available. For W6 only: the frame vocabulary AND the prior frame labels are off-limits. The reasoning must be there; neither label can be used.

CONSTRAINT

Answer the prompt below without using the words tension, priority, or judgment — and without naming which prior frame (for example, 'trade-off' or 'scale') you're drawing on. The reasoning must be there; the labels cannot.

PROMPT

"Should countries replace their current retirement age with a flexible retirement window based on job type?"

Fallback Strategies to Practice

a

Circumlocution

Instead of "my judgment is," try "what makes the most sense here is" or "the strongest conclusion is."

b

Term substitution

Instead of naming a prior frame directly ("there's a trade-off between X and Y"), just do the reasoning without labeling it.

c

Self-correction

"What I mean is..." / "Let me put that another way..."

d

Hedging

"It seems like the strongest case is..." / "This tends to matter more when..."

Instructor note: use only after a student is reliably integrating a prior frame by name in Activities 1a–4b. This tests whether the reasoning survives once all scaffolding language disappears entirely — a stress test, not a first attempt.